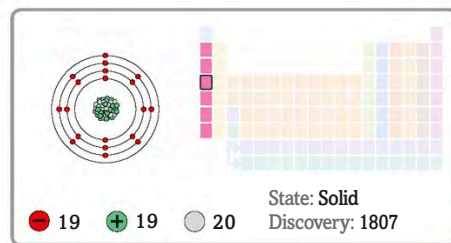


19

K

Potassium



Forms



Potash

This mineral is rich in potassium chloride.

This glass case holding pure potassium has no air in it, preventing the metal from reacting with oxygen in air.

Laboratory sample of pure potassium in an airless vial



Soft and shiny solid

The yellow and green colour comes from impurities.



This mineral contains potassium chloride, which gives it a salty taste.

Sylvite



Potassium was first found in the dust of burnt plants. It was discovered by Sir Humphry Davy when he experimented with **potash** – a mixture of substances made from the ash of burnt plants soaked in water. The name potassium comes from potash but the

element's chemical symbol, K, is taken from *kalium*, a Latin word for “ash”. Potassium is never found pure in nature, but is present in minerals such as **apthitalite** and **sylvite**. Potassium is vital for the human body, helping muscles and nerves work properly. For this, we rely on